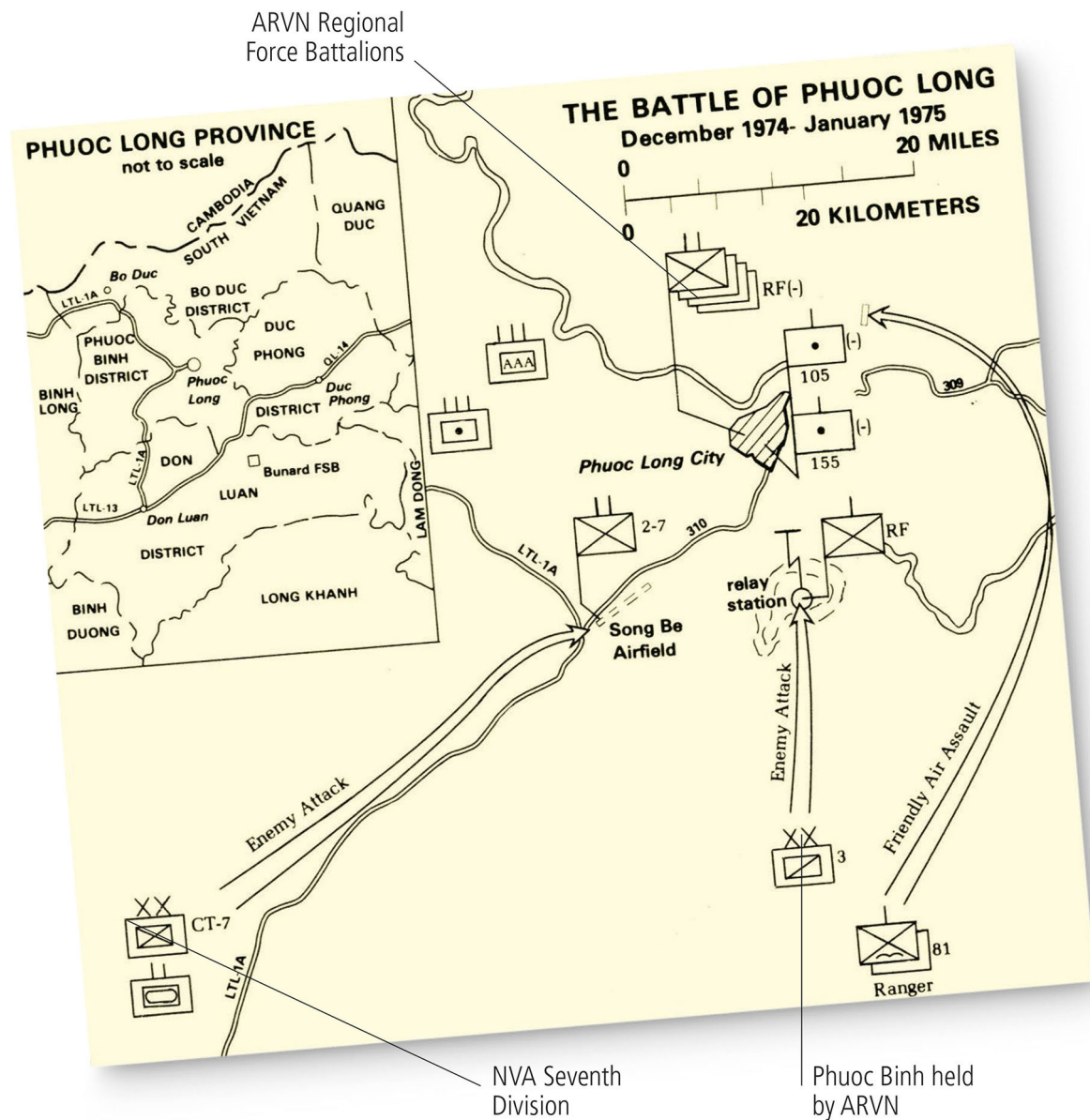




Battle plan

This map of the battle of Phuoc Long from the US Center of Military History shows the initial attack by two divisions of the NVA 301st Corps and the airlift of ARVN reinforcements into Phuoc Binh (Phuoc Long City).

Decisive moment

Only 850 of the 5,000 or more South Vietnamese troops engaged in the fighting escaped either death or capture. President Thieu announced three days of national mourning after the defeat and vowed to retake Phuoc Binh. However, this promise was empty bravado. With the loss of Phuoc Binh and the evident withdrawal of American support, Thieu saw his prestige plummeting.

The communist victory at Phuoc Long was decisive for two reasons. Firstly, the lack of any active response from Washington showed that the US was no longer prepared to guarantee the existence of South Vietnam. The US made a formal protest, accusing Hanoi of seeking to impose a military solution on Vietnam, but at a press conference on January 21, 1975, President Ford stated that he could foresee no circumstances under which